

Evernote acquires Penultimate

Penultimate, the most popular digital handwriting recognition iOS app has joined the Evernote family



Electric charging gets speed boost

New Schneider Electric Charger can charge 80% of your car battery in less than half an hour

like Google is quite strong financially and may never go away, but there's a company like MegaUpload, which has been shut down by the government, thereby users lost a lot of their data. So it's pretty clear. Do you have all your money in one bank or do you have some of it home? There's this whole battle of mine versus theirs. We're just giving users a choice. Plus there's no monthly fee involved.

1 So there's no revenue model?

For us there's a revenue model. You buy the product, pay that one-time fee and then you can use the service for free.

1 Could you elaborate on WD's enterprise segment and its overall contribution to your bottomline?

The company started in 1970 as a semi-conductor company. By the 80s we had transitioned to a controller and board company. By late 80s we transitioned to a hard drive company. So we are one of the few companies who have transitioned somewhat like a cockroach - hard to kill. So we are very much step-by-step. We come from the PC world, so that is our main segment. The enterprise world is very far from us. Although we do have a 25 percent share in the enterprise segment, the type we are looking at is typically mirrorline or SATA or mission or business critical. It's the next tier up the enterprise, which is high speed and high performance which we recently announced, our third generation products - the S25 900GB and the 1TB Velociraptor. So we are still early considering we are third generation for an enterprise product. Typically it takes 2 or 3 generations to get more momentum.

1 To assist you with this, have you partnered with any companies globally or in India?

Oh yes. Enterprise products have a very extensive compatibility because there's a large number of things such as the RAID controller. For example, the Caviar brand has a very specific compatibility, it is designed for the PC. The Scorpio brand is designed for the notebook. The AV brand is designed for set-top boxes or surveillance, etc. So we have a tremendously successful partner program to

test the inter-operability and compatibility on the development side. On the sales and marketing side, we sell directly to the largest OEMs, benefit of being in the industry for a long time. We still have work to do, but we have a 24-time zone distribution channel covering many countries. So are we successful in India as we would want to be? No. What are we doing about it? We are investing, in the right people, investing in the partners, investing in the capabilities.

1 Could you elaborate on WD's SSD plans?

So according to our research from the 500,000 petabytes of data that was transferred last year, only 20,000 petabytes were using flash drives. That amounts to a mere 4 percent overall data transfer share. So that's an interesting statistic that flash is only 4 percent of the overall storage. The current SSD products we have under the WD brand were got from a company we acquired called Silicon Systems, they are focussed on the embedded industrial market places, which are the closest markets to the enterprise which equates to high duty cycle, high reliability and very long life-cycle. And that was the strategy.

With regards to consumer market, we are very much in support of this dual hybrid drive. We have teams working on SSD products, but we won't announce products before we are shipping. Safe to say we are investing.

1 A lot of WD media players have come out in the market, so how do you see that particular segment's growth?

We would have told you in the past that we are only interested in the storage of your data, and that is our core business. The products you see in WD's portfolio transport data, there's powerline network products, there are products that consume your data such as the HD media players. So we're very focussed on the connected home. We aren't the only company to use that term. We think we do a pretty good job on the ease of use. The brand WD, for many people, perhaps not as much in India, but many feel that the brand gives good products, it's an easy to use service, it's got a good support. And so, we are interested in the entire eco-system

at home. I will say it is a very difficult product to offer services on, as video services differ from country to country. That is very unique for us. Most of our products we can launch in 24 different time zones and 40 languages. Languages are not as hard as you think, but getting the content from country to country - that's very hard.

1 When testing the WD HD media players, we noticed that many of the video services such as Netflix, Pandora, Radiofly etc., don't work in the Indian market. Can those be replaced by more local content? What are your thoughts on tie-ups with content providers on this front?

Now that's challenging. The video content market in the world, specially people who own the copyright to the video, license it on a country by country basis. So, if you go back to Hollywood or Bollywood, there is a strong reason why they have a strong IP, it's a hard business for us. As for tie-ups I don't have any announcements. We have dedicated resources working specifically on content relationships country by country. But in the media player category, whether you have Apple computers or WD or any other suppliers, it is hard to build a library of content. So we have work to do there.

1 How does WD maintain its first mover advantage? It was the first to come out with a 3TB drive with the advanced 4K format; then recently you announced a portable 2TB drive.

With success you are able to invest more, you are able to hire more specialised people, that allows you to do more products. We are a 42-year old company that is a long time. This industry has seen a lot of mergers and acquisitions and fortunately we have been the people buying. We have a lot of products and dedicated teams working on them. They keep getting better at what they do. 

READ MORE AT:
dgit.in/WDInterview_june2012

thinkdigit
VIRAL | TECH | GEEK | JUNK | JAZZ